

ASSOCIATION OF LIBERAL ARTS UNITS AT TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITIES



The School of Foundational Studies at Kettering University

Institutional Profile · Pre-Planning Meeting · April 10, 2026 · Atlanta, GA

Ronald J. Tackett, Ph.D.

Founding Head, School of Foundational Studies · Associate Professor of Physics

Kettering University · Flint, Michigan

Kettering
UNIVERSITY

KETTERING UNIVERSITY

~1,300

undergrad enrollment (fall 2025)

#18 / #11

US News: undergrad engineering & Regional Midwest

12:1

student-faculty ratio

~99%

Co-op placement within 1 year of enrollment

~\$20+/hr

avg. Co-op wage

\$80,275

median salary 6 yrs after graduation (US News)

SCHOOL OF FOUNDATIONAL STUDIES

22

full-time faculty

Founding Head

Ronald J. Tackett, Ph.D. (est. 2025)

Academic Scope

Math, Physics, Economics, Humanities, Social Sciences

Non-Degree Granting

serves all Kettering students

Minor portfolio

under active review & development

Reports to Provost

equal structural standing
direct line to the President

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- 1919** **Founded as School of Automobile Trades, Flint, MI**
Co-op model embedded from the start: students alternated between classroom and factory floor.
 - 1926** **Acquired by General Motors -- renamed General Motors Institute (GMI)**
Became GM's primary training ground for engineers & managers. Known as the 'West Point of the Automobile Industry.'
 - 1946** **First bachelor's degrees granted**
Thesis requirement added in 1945; bachelor's degrees conferred beginning 1946, formalizing GMI's academic standing.
 - 1982** **Independence from GM -- renamed GMI Engineering & Management Institute**
On July 1, 1982, GM divested. The university became a private, non-profit institution charting its own academic future.
 - 1998** **Renamed Kettering University, honoring Charles 'Boss' Kettering**
Legendary inventor of the electric self-starter, former GM head of research, and lifelong champion of Co-op education.
 - 2025** **School of Foundational Studies established (July 2025)**
Ron Tackett appointed Founding Head. Math, sciences, humanities, and communication are consolidated under a unified academic school.

Key insight: SoFS was built to give coherence and institutional voice to disciplines that already existed across the university; the result of deliberate design, not simply reorganization. As one of Kettering's founders put it: "If we taught musicians the way we teach engineers, we would make them take 12 years of music theory before we ever let them touch a piano."

Why we say “Foundational Studies”

In an engineering culture, “liberal arts” signals optionality. “Foundational” signals load-bearing, conveying that it is essential to everything above it.

WHAT SoFS ENCOMPASSES

- Mathematics
- Physics
- Economics
- Humanities
- Social Sciences



At Kettering, we are striving to treat the liberal arts not as a requirement to be satisfied, but as the intellectual infrastructure on which sound engineering judgment is built.

THE CHALLENGE & THE OPPORTUNITY

Our academic home: Faculty teaching mathematics, physics, economics, humanities, and social sciences.

Administered elsewhere: Engineering courses; chemistry and biology (administered by CEMS); management courses

The tension: Being the foundation means you are essential; but foundations are invisible when everything above them is standing.

Our response: Document, advocate, and make the SoFS contribution legible across the institution.



Structural Status

The SoFS is a School reporting directly to the Provost; parallel to, but separate from, the College of Engineering & Science. We hold governance standing equal to technical units.



Faculty Composition

The SoFS is building a mixed faculty model: a small number of tenured faculty, a majority of Teaching Professors and Lecturers, and one or two tenure-track lines. P&T criteria are being developed to reflect this intentional mix.



Hiring & Budget

The SoFS controls its own faculty searches within Provost-approved budget envelopes. Teaching-focused lines; limited external research infrastructure compared to engineering units. Still some focus on scholarly activity for the tenured and tenure-track faculty



Teaching Loads & Service

Tenured, tenure-track, and Teaching Professors teach 3 of 4 terms; Lecturers teach all 4. Contact hours range from 24 to 48 per year, depending on rank and role, reflecting a deliberately teaching-intensive mission. All roles have some expectation of service to the School.



Governance & Representation

The SoFS Head sits on the Council of Deans. Curriculum governance runs through the SoFS Curriculum Council, which represents the SoFS at the University Curriculum Committee (UCC). Two tenured SoFS faculty serve as elected Faculty Senate Senators.



Curriculum Integration

The SoFS courses are hard prerequisites for all engineering sequences, with math and physics courses building the technical engineering foundations. Beyond that, our curriculum is woven into every engineering degree plan.



Strategic Initiatives

The SoFS is actively shaping the Engineering Common Core: implementing the PIVOT integrative learning sequence, embedding liberal arts into project-based engineering courses, and developing upper-level technology & society electives to deepen liberal arts engagement later in the curriculum.



Research & Collaboration

The SoFS is a teaching-focused school whose tenured and tenure-track faculty maintain active scholarly agendas across all disciplines, with natural points of collaboration with engineering and independent research collaborations.



Recognition & Inclusion

Are we sufficiently recognized? Honestly, we are making progress. The SoFS now has a seat at major curriculum tables. The goal (moving away from an identity as a service unit to one as an indispensable academic partner) is a work in progress.

Years 1 - 4

SoFS integrated across the full engineering journey

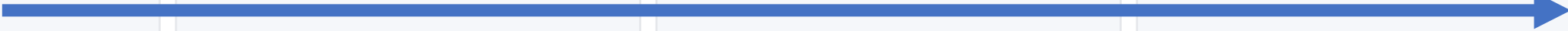
PIVOT

integrative thread connecting LA, Co-op, and engineering practice

T&S Minor

new Technology & Society pathway via technical electives

Scaffolded Liberal Arts Sequence Across the Full Curriculum:

Years 1-2 (Foundation)	Years 2-3 (Integration)	Years 3-4 (Depth & Choice)	Year 4 (Synthesis)
Highest concentration of SoFS-led coursework: - Mathematics - Physics - Written Communication - Economics	SoFS-centric to a more engineering-focused with SoFS support: - Intermediate electives: - Humanities - Social Science - SoFS & Engineering Core	Shift to a liberal arts framework applied to engineering contexts: - Advanced electives: - Humanities - Social Science - SoFS & Engineering Core	General education focus shifts towards a leadership mindset: - Integrative LA Captone - Courses at the intersection of the liberal arts and technology
PIVOT Core Values 			

Engineering technical electives within the engineering curricula are being opened to LA-intersection courses, creating a pathway toward a proposed Technology & Society minor developed and owned by SoFS faculty.

What Kettering & the SoFS Bring to This Association



A Founding Story

We bring the experience of building a liberal arts school from within a STEM institution. Navigating the politics, constructing the governance, and forging a shared identity out of disciplines that once had none. That process has taught us things you can't learn any other way.



A Tested Branding Model

We bring a naming and framing strategy that has been tested in an engineering culture. "Foundational Studies" isn't just a title; it's an argument. We can share what we've learned about why the framing matters, what's worked, and where we still have more to figure out.



The Small-Institution Perspective

We bring the small-institution voice. At Kettering, there is not institutional bugger between us and the skepticism; every course, every term, has to make the case to students who are asking out loud why it matters. That discipline sharpens your argument in ways that scale matters for this association.



Genuine Commitment

We bring a genuine conviction that foundational education is not adjacent to engineering education; it is part of it. As AI reshapes entry-level work, the question is no longer whether to integrate liberal arts and professional experience; it is whether institutions can reorganize themselves to do what Kettering figured out.

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